

THE LESSONS OF HISTORY

HAVING GIVEN UP THE IDEA OF FINANCIAL PLANNING, BUT still looking for some sort of guidance, I headed for the local library. I hoped to learn as much as I could from the newsletters and business publications, which there, at least, were free. Several weeks into my venture, my money was sitting in the savings account, multiplying at the paltry rate of 5½ percent per annum. No doubt countless fortunes had been made while I'd been watching television, or frittering away my time at M. H. Senzel, yet I refused to succumb to impatience. The lessons of history would not be lost on me.

In the reading room, I encountered a variety of individuals with stuck zippers on their pants and grease stains on their sweatshirts. I knew we shared an interest after I saw them absorbed in the *Wall Street Journal*. One made odd chewing noises as he perused the stock tables. Another spread rusted wristwatches across his cubicle space, and sang "Way Down Upon the Swanee River" in defiance of the QUIET signs. I asked him what investment he would make, and he mumbled "Key Pharmaceutical," a stock which has gone up handsomely since.

Well-informed students of the market can be found loitering in most libraries. From what I could observe, most of them lack capital. I decided these were former average investors who had carried my previous techniques (buy high, sell low, break about even) to an ultimate conclusion: sleeping in the alley, eating from the trash bins, living out their days in the reading room.

I could have spent more time talking to them, but fearing the effects of a prolonged association, I isolated myself in the stacks. There I scanned or studied more than 200 books about investing